

POTTER OF MEDICINE

THE COMPLETE USMLE GUIDE

STEP 1 & STEP 2 CK

A student's own story, and the system behind it

DANIYAL SHAHID

بِسْمِ ٱللَّهِ ٱلرَّحْمَٰنِ ٱلرَّحِيمِ

In the name of Allah, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful



صَلَّى ٱللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ

Lots of blessings on Prophet Muhammad (S.A.W.)



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STEP 1 & STEP 2 CK

Resources, schedules, mistakes and mindset, all in one place

DANIYAL SHAHID

DEDICATED TO

My parents,

and my grandfather

Dr. Mushtaq Ahmed

my mentor, through every year of medicine

BEFORE THE FIRST PAGE

PREFACE

Bismillah. Before I give you a single line of advice, I owe some thank-yous, and they come first.

This booklet began as a few notes and screenshots I kept for my students. Over time the same questions kept coming back to me. Where do I start? What do I do after UWorld? When should I book my exam? So I sat down, in between lectures and busy OPD hours, and wrote everything in one place, the way I would explain it to you across a table.

None of it would exist without the people who stood behind me.

To my parents, for their prayers, their patience, and for believing in me long before I had anything to show for it. Every exam I have cleared carries your names on it.

To my grandfather, Dr. Mushtaq Ahmed, who was my mentor throughout my whole medical life. He guided me through every stage of this road, and whatever is useful in these pages carries his influence. This booklet is dedicated to the three of you.

If it helps even one student walk into the exam hall a little calmer and a little better prepared, I will consider the effort worthwhile. Whatever is right in here is by the grace of Allah, and any mistake is my own.

Karachi

Daniyal Shahid
POTTER OF MEDICINE

INSIDE THIS BOOKLET

CONTENTS

Preface 5

Introduction 7

PART ONE · USMLE STEP 1

How to Cover the Basics 9

How to Solve UWorld 14

NBME Self-Assessments 16

When to Book the Exam? 18

Test Day 18

PART TWO · USMLE STEP 2 CK

The Complete Roadmap: Introduction 21

The Foundation: Two Pillars 21

The Big Picture 23

- Phase 1 · How to Solve UWorld 24
- Phase 2 · Divine Intervention Podcasts 25
- Phase 3 · CMS Forms and UWorld Second Pass 26
- Phase 4 · AMBOSS High-Yield 26
- Phase 5 · NBME Forms 28
- Phase 6 · The Final Stretch 30

The Playbook: Five Rules 32

HELLO, EVERYONE

INTRODUCTION

Hello, everyone! My name is Daniyal. I am currently a final year medical student and USMLE Step 3 aspirant. I cleared my USMLE Step 1 in third year, and USMLE Step 2 CK in fourth year. I have been coaching USMLE students, nationally and internationally, for almost two years.

I am writing this in a chaotic OPD, where everyone is rushing to be seen by the doctors, but it's my dedication to the students that is keeping my cerebral cortex focused enough to write a useful guide for them. Read every single detail written in this guide, as it is for you. It's not only a guide, it also includes my personal experiences, and among those experiences, extract what's best for you!

Take what is best for you.

THAT IS THE WHOLE IDEA

PART ONE

USMLE STEP 1

The basics, the long road of UWorld,
and the mock exams that tell you the truth

CHAPTER ONE

HOW TO COVER THE BASICS

Hello, everyone! This booklet covers the complete guide for the USMLEs. We'll start our discussion from USMLE Step 1. Step 1 is the pre-clinical exam that covers the basics of medical sciences: physiology, anatomy, pharmacology, biochemistry, microbiology and pathology. Pathology covers the major portion of the exam. In this chapter our major focus is "how to cover the basics for USMLE Step 1".

My suggestion for every Step 1 candidate is to always take a systemic approach, rather than a subject-wise approach. For example, starting from GIT is a better approach than starting from pathology for all systems at once. But here comes a general rule: one should make the base before constructing a building. That's why one should take a very initial step through pathology, pharmacology and micro basics, before entering the world of systems. Having said that, the very next question would be, "how to cover these basic subjects then?" There are a lot of resources for the preparation of USMLEs, but one should choose the most self-suitable resource.

As a medical student, one should be concerned about pathology, and being concerned does not mean that you have to memorize every single word written in the long books. You should hold a strong grip on the principles. To ace every subject, and every field, you need a strong grip on principles; the rest is how you apply them. That's why I recommend a strong grip on the first three chapters of **Pathoma**. Pathoma is a very concise resource of pathology, by Dr. Husain Sattar, MD, that covers the principles of pathology, and those principles literally work in every direction of medicine. For the

remaining subjects I recommend **Boards & Beyond** by Dr. Jason Ryan, MD. Boards & Beyond is a comprehensive resource for the USMLEs that has been a major pillar for many candidates for a long time. The reference book while watching Boards & Beyond lectures is always **First Aid**.

THEN, THE SYSTEMS

Once you cover these basic subjects, move towards the systems, and that's where the systemic approach starts, around which you revolve throughout your preparation. Ideally you should cover the major systems within three months. The major systems include GIT, Neurology, Cardiovascular, Hematology & Oncology, Respiratory, Endocrinology, Musculoskeletal and Renal.

One should start systems from GIT, but why? GIT is one of the longest systems, and covering it will be your first relief in the preparation phase. By the time you come towards the end of this three-month period, having only small systems left is a big relief! After completing GIT you can move towards CVS and Neuro, then Hematology & Oncology, and the rest in the manner you prefer.

WHICH VIDEO RESOURCES?

Now, which video resources should you use in this three-month period? There are many out there, but two are major: Boards & Beyond, and **Bootcamp**. If you want a cut-to-the-chase resource, Boards & Beyond will be your companion. But if you want something more explanatory, or if you are not good with Boards & Beyond just because of the monotonous accent of the guy, then Bootcamp can be your companion.

But what about micro? It makes a major chunk of Step 1; in each block of the actual exam you might encounter 5–6 questions from micro. As far as my own experience and my peers' experience is concerned, **Sketchy** is the most trusted, concise and retainable resource for micro. It's just like Netflix, you can complete five episodes per day. I'd suggest having a cup of coffee while watching it, or watching it over dinner. It's highly recommended to get your Sketchy covered at least twice in your three-month period.

I also recommend Sketchy for pharmacology, but at times the sketches for pharmacology are too vague to retain. For such topics you can rely on First Aid's pharmacology section, and for the rest you can continue with Sketchy.

Now, we are left with Psychiatry, Dermatology, Reproduction, Biochemistry, Ethics and Biostatistics. These all form a considerable portion of the exam. In the next chapter we'll discuss how to cover them, but for now keep in mind that they are covered via UWorld; you don't need any video resource for them.

To clarify, this three-month basics period is necessary for someone who has never studied pathology, pharmacology and microbiology so far. If you have studied these subjects in the past years of medical school, I'd suggest starting your preparation directly from UWorld, because you don't need to begin from the very basics. That covers what you are expected to finish in the three-month basics period.

BELIEVE IN YOUR LORD, AND YOURSELF

Within these months, I personally faced a lot of difficulties. Among all of them, the thing that kept disturbing me was: am I in the right direction or not? Am I walking aimlessly? Did I choose the right path or not? I answered all of these questions with just one answer, "believe in your Lord, and yourself". These few words worked for me in every stance of life.

Believe in your Lord, and yourself.

THE ANSWER TO EVERY DOUBT

I'd suggest the reader of this book tunnel his or her vision, with the other end of the tunnel towards the outcome. I chose this word because a tunnel is a closed pipe with no distractions, just one pathway. In the early stages of life people never realize the importance of mindset. Mindset can make you cross mountains, if you plan properly, and most importantly, strategically. A strategic plan can bring you out of any hardship, since a plan is a set of organized ideas.

MY ROUTINE, AND A BETTER ONE

Many people ask, "what was your routine, your schedule during these days?" To be very honest, I have been an owl when it comes to studies. I used to stay up all night, attend the university in the morning, try to extract the maximum out of my day there, and then take a nap after reaching home. This was without a doubt a very hectic schedule, and I never recommend anyone to be so cruel to themselves.

Instead, wake up early in the morning, preferably 40 to 50 minutes before sunrise, offer your prayers, and have a cup of coffee. Then continue your day at the university, and study at home or the university till 7 to 8 pm. This will keep your circadian rhythm in line with the actual exam, since the exam will be in the morning.

HOW TO REVISE IN THIS PHASE

Another query I frequently encounter is, "how do I revise, specifically in this phase when I am not solving UWorld?" There are two methods of revision, active and passive. In the passive method you simply open the book and read it out in a retainable fashion, whereas in the active method you solve a Q-bank. In this three-month phase, I highly recommend the **AMBOSS** Q-bank.

How to use AMBOSS, then? Do 10 questions a day, at the end of your day. Let's suppose you are studying Cardiovascular; at the end of the day, practice 10 questions from AMBOSS for Cardiovascular. A more specific plan is to start AMBOSS right after getting done with one of the systems. Start AMBOSS for Cardiology when you are done with it, and while you study the next module, practice cardiology questions at the end of the day. Once you are done with that second module, add it to those 10 questions and move on to the next. If you are someone who is not up for solving AMBOSS daily, you can simply do 40 to 50 questions at once on the weekend.

After following this schedule, you'll be done with the basics, and then comes the most disciplined part of our preparation: solving UWorld!

CHAPTER TWO

HOW TO SOLVE UWORLD

Without a doubt it is the most disciplined part of the preparation. In this phase you just solve questions, and more questions. For Step 1, I highly recommend solving UWorld in test and random mode. The test mode prepares you for time management in the actual examination, whereas the random mode prepares you for the actual randomness of the exam. An ideal schedule would be:

MORNING	Take a test of 40 questions. The blocks are divided into 20 questions for now, but try to solve 40 questions in one hour. The test should be in timed mode, and should be finished within that hour.
REST OF THE DAY	Focus on reviewing the whole block. Read the explanation from UWorld, and then read the same topic from your prime resource. It could be First Aid, Sketchy, Pathoma, or whatever resource you used.

ADDING SYSTEMS AND SUBJECTS

How do you add systems and subjects in UWorld? It should be done in a very organized way. I am a fan of keeping things super organized, so I organized my preparation with an Excel sheet. I do the same with my students.

For subjects, I added Pathology, Pathophysiology, Anatomy, Physiology, Social Sciences (Ethics), Microbiology, Pharmacology and all the basics, and left Biostatistics and Genetics for now. For systems, I added three of my favorites, and left out the ones I mentioned leaving in the first phase as well (Psychiatry, Dermatology, Reproduction, Biochemistry, Ethics and Biostatistics). I kept the subjects the same but continued adding three more systems every week, till I was left with these six. I continued this till I reached 40% of my UWorld.

Once I reached 40%, I started adding the six leftovers one by one. It went like this: 40 questions a day from a random block, and a block of 10 questions from one leftover at the end of the day, for at least four days. On the fifth day I added that one into the random block of 40, and continued with the next one, till all six leftovers were in random mode. Finally, you have all of the systems and subjects in the same randomized block.

Then continue UWorld in the same manner till you complete it. I suggest taking one NBME in the midst of solving UWorld to get an idea of where you are heading. I make my students take NBME-25 by 60% of UWorld. *(Note: this NBME will just give you an idea of the exam, and of time management.)*

CHAPTER THREE

NBME SELF-ASSESSMENTS

One of the terrible phases of the preparation, yet self-rewarding

This phase starts with the NBME-25 that you took in the middle of your UWorld.

Exam environment. Simulate the exam conditions. I cannot emphasize this enough! It is so necessary in order to assess yourself and prepare for the exam day, as sitting in an 8-hour exam is not a joke at all. So sit in a quiet and peaceful environment, and divide the whole 200-question form into five blocks of 40 questions. Give yourself one hour for each block, and take a 5 to 7 minute break after each block. Keep a digital stopwatch with you, and don't keep your phone in your surroundings; put it aside, or in a different room.

Once done with the test, take the rest of the day off. Chill! You have done enough.

Review. This is one of the crucial steps of your preparation. Make an Excel sheet; a sample is shown below. Mark the correct ones green, the guessed-correct ones yellow, and the incorrect ones red.

Question number	Topic	System	Comments
1	RCC	Renal	I recognized the buzzwords, and marked correct
2	Stroke	Neuro	I forgot the MRI findings

A sample of the review sheet: green for correct, red for incorrect.

Trust me, this will show you yourself in a way that lets you diagnose yourself. If there are a lot of mistakes due to a knowledge gap in a specific system, work on it from UWorld every other day: solve 10 to 20 questions from that system at the end of your day.

The first NBME should be attempted at 60% of UWorld, whereas the next one should be attempted once you are done with 100% of UWorld.

Follow the series of NBMEs till 28, and if your scores are above 65%, continue till the latest form and then appear in the exam. If the scores aren't satisfactory till NBME-28, stop the chain and start the series again from NBME-20. The rationale for going back to the older NBMEs when your scores aren't improving is that, most of the time, it is the question style that you are not following. UWorld makes you an over-thinker, whereas NBMEs are pretty straightforward, and that is one of the common reasons for not scoring well enough on NBMEs.

CHAPTER FOUR

WHEN TO BOOK THE EXAM?

This literally depends on your preparation, and don't rush it. The day you hit your first satisfactory score, book the triad, and then book the date with a gap of 20 days from your desired date of the exam. Just do it now, don't think much!

CHAPTER FIVE

TEST DAY

Finally, the day arrives, and all of your hard work, long sittings and consistency are going to be rewarded by the grace of Allah. Have a light, yet caffeinated breakfast. Reach the test center at least 30 minutes prior to the reporting time. Don't carry any book along with you; your mind and your muscle memory are enough.

Take protein bars and energy drinks with you. I personally suggest taking a highly caffeinated cold coffee!

Take a break after every block, even if it's only two minutes. You can also sit in peace at the exam desk for two minutes after every 20-question block, and then take a dedicated 5 to 6 minute break after two blocks.

Wear an outfit with fewer pockets, so that every time you leave the examination room for a break, it takes less time for the invigilators to check you.

Once you are done with the exam, take the letter that confirms you have attempted it, and then rest and pray for the next two weeks. Do not overthink the results. Trust your Lord, trust your NBME scores, and trust yourself.

That's pretty much from my side for Step 1. If you have any other concerns or queries you can always reach me at the contact details at the end of this booklet.

PART TWO

USMLE STEP 2 CK

Six phases, one sequence,
and a system you can trust

THE NEXT CHAPTER OF THE SAME STORY

USMLE STEP 2 CK

The Complete Roadmap

In my Step 1 guide, I covered how to build the basics and how to survive the long road of UWorld and NBMEs. This part is the next chapter of the same story. It is my Step 2 CK journey, written as a step-by-step system: what to do, in what order, and when to move on. It is not only a guide, it also includes my personal experiences, and among those experiences, extract what's best for you!

STEP 2 CK

THE FOUNDATION

Two pillars of Step 2 CK

Before we start, let me clear one thing: Step 2 CK is not a new exam that starts from zero. It stands on two pillars.

Step 1 is your foundation. A strong Step 1 base makes Step 2 CK preparation much faster. In Step 1 you learn the pathophysiology; in Step 2 CK, diagnosis and management start to connect to it as one chain. If your Step 1 was not perfect, don't panic and don't wait. Start anyway, because weak spots show up very early in UWorld, and you can patch them right away, one by one.

UWorld is your engine. Step 2 CK preparation relies heavily on UWorld. Plan for two passes: your first pass, and then your incorrects. Treat the explanations as teaching content, not just an answer key. CMS forms, NBMEs and AMBOSS all plug in around it.

Step 1 gives you the roots,
and UWorld grows the tree.

MY ONE-LINE SUMMARY

THE BIG PICTURE

Here is the whole roadmap in one look, and then we'll go through each phase in detail.

1. **UWORLD PASS 1**
   Random + Tutor mode for your first 2 to 3 months.
2. **DIVINE INTERVENTION PODCASTS**
   Start at around 30% of UWorld.
3. **CMS FORMS + UWORLD PASS 2**
   The latest 3 CMS forms per system, along with your UWorld incorrects in test mode.
4. **AMBOSS HIGH-YIELD**
   HPI, nutrition, drug ads, biostats and the 200 concepts.
5. **NBMES**
   UWSA 1 first, then NBME 9 or 10 up to the latest forms, with 1 to 3 AMBOSS hammer questions every day.
6. **THE FINAL STRETCH**
   AMBOSS Qbank as needed, UWSA 3, and then exam day.

The most important thing here is the sequence. Each phase sets up the next one, so don't skip ahead.

PHASE ONE

HOW TO SOLVE UWORLD

First pass

Just like Step 1, this is the most disciplined part of the preparation, and you start it right at the beginning. Give your first pass around two to three months, and solve it in **Random + Tutor mode**.

Random mode mixes every system in each block. It trains you to switch gears from one specialty to another, which is exactly how the actual exam behaves. **Tutor mode** shows you the explanation right after each question, so you learn while you test, instead of after.

Notice the difference from Step 1, where I recommended test mode. In Step 1, the early focus was time management. In Step 2 CK, the first pass is about learning the clinical approach, so tutor mode serves you better here.

My suggested daily rhythm is very simple:

1. **DO A BLOCK**
   One block at a time, in random and tutor mode.
2. **READ EVERY EXPLANATION**
   Don't skim the ones you got right. A correct answer with a wrong reason is a hidden mistake.
3. **LOG WHAT YOU MISSED**
   Keep an Excel sheet, just as I suggested for Step 1. Your incorrects are about to become your syllabus.

PHASE TWO

DIVINE INTERVENTION PODCASTS

Once you hit **30% of UWorld**, press play on the Divine Intervention podcasts. Don't start them earlier, because you need some base of clinical questions first, and don't wait until the end either.

The beauty of podcasts is that they convert dead time into revision. Commutes, walks, the gym, and breaks between sessions can all become study time. I am writing this guide in a chaotic OPD, so believe me when I say I understand how precious pockets of time are!

Two rules for podcasts. First, they **reinforce, they don't replace**. Podcasts stack on top of your UWorld blocks and never take their place. Second, keep going with UWorld until you reach 100%, and then move straight into CMS forms.

PHASE THREE

CMS FORMS & UWORLD SECOND PASS

When your first pass of UWorld is complete, you run two tracks side by side.

Track A: CMS forms. Solve the latest 3 forms from every system. Begin only once your UWorld first pass is complete.

Track B: UWorld incorrects. Redo your incorrects, this time in **test mode**. There is no instant feedback here, so you get exam-style pressure while revisiting your weak spots.

Give this phase around two months. Finish your second pass of UWorld along with the CMS forms in these months. This is where your Excel sheet pays off, because every question you logged in Phase 1 is now a topic you are fixing.

PHASE FOUR

AMBOSS HIGH-YIELD

After that, sharpen your preparation with the **High-Yield section of AMBOSS**. My advice is to stick to what is inside this section: focused, exam-relevant, and no rabbit holes. You don't need to read

the entire library, and trying to do so is one of the biggest traps.

The High-Yield section includes:

- **HPI questions.** Read the story, spot the diagnosis, and choose the next step.
- **Nutrition.** Deficiencies and nutrition scenarios that show up on the exam.
- **Drug ads.** Learn to judge the claims and the evidence in drug advertisements.
- **Biostats.** Study design, bias and statistics, which are quick and reliable points.
- **The 200 concepts.** The concepts that appear in every exam. Know them cold.
- **And more.** Everything else flagged in the High-Yield section.

PHASE FIVE

NBME FORMS

Your reality check

This is the phase where you find out where you really stand, and just like in Step 1, it is a terrible phase of the preparation, yet self-rewarding.

Start with **UWSA 1** before you take your first NBME. Then begin with **NBME 9 or 10**, and move forward form by form, working through the series in order, until you finish on the latest NBMEs, but keep the 3 to 4 latest forms of NBME for the final stretch.

Exam environment. Simulate the exam conditions, just as I explained in the Step 1 part. Timed, distraction-free, and exam-style. Put your phone in a different room, keep a stopwatch with you, and take your breaks the way you will take them on the real day. Sitting through a full-length exam is not a joke, and your stamina needs rehearsal as much as your knowledge does.

Review. Use the same method as before. Review every form in an Excel sheet and diagnose yourself honestly. Mark the correct ones green, the guessed-correct ones yellow, and the incorrect ones red. The guessed ones deserve as much attention as the wrong ones.

Running in parallel. Solve 1 to 3 AMBOSS hammer questions every day while you work through the NBMEs. The forms test your stamina, while these daily questions keep your everyday clinical knowledge from slipping. I beg of you, please use this as a tool to fill the gaps that appeared while

attempting the NBMEs. Try to bring your scores to at least 240 in this phase; otherwise, don't move towards Phase 6. Use the AMBOSS Qbank, AMBOSS articles, your revision notes, or try redoing NBMEs.

A NOTE FROM ME

You are your own doctor here, and you are the one who is going to make the diagnosis of yourself. While reviewing and checking the NBME answers, be brutally honest with yourself. Don't say, "Oh! It's just a random mistake, let me add +1 to my score." I repeat, don't! These are your diagnostic tests. A wrong diagnostic test leads to wrong treatment, hence complications, and leaves the disease untreated!

PHASE SIX

THE FINAL STRETCH

This is the finishing phase, and it is simpler than people think.

AMBOSS QBANK	Use it as needed, to patch the weak spots that your forms exposed. Use it as a repair tool, not as a new mountain to climb.
UWSA 2	Take it while you are left with 3 to 4 NBME forms.
LEFT-OVER NBME FORMS	Complete the remaining NBME forms.
UWSA 3	This is your last self-assessment. Take it 4 to 5 days before the exam, only if you want to, and if you want to increase your stamina.

Exam day. The test-day habits from the Step 1 part remain the same here: a light yet caffeinated breakfast, reaching the center early, taking your breaks seriously, and wearing an outfit with fewer pockets. Walk in with a system, not just hope.

Once you are done, rest and pray. Don't overthink the result. Trust your Lord, trust your forms, and trust yourself.

You didn't get lucky.
You followed a system.

EXAM DAY

THE PLAYBOOK

FIVE RULES THAT MAKE THE PLAN WORK

I **Follow the sequence.** Each phase sets up the next, so don't skip ahead.

II **Explanations over scores.** The learning happens after you answer.

III **Treat incorrects as your syllabus.** They become your second pass.

IV **Rehearse like it's exam day.** Do NBMEs and UWSAs timed, distraction-free, and exam-style.

V **Protect your baseline.** Daily AMBOSS questions, sleep, and breaks keep you sharp.

Consistency beats cramming. Show up daily, and trust the order. Just as I told you in the Step 1 part, tunnel your vision towards the outcome, believe in your Lord, and believe in yourself.

“May Allah be with you; lots of blessings on Prophet Muhammad (S.A.W.)!”

If you have any other concerns or queries, you can always reach me. I also provide one-on-one tutoring, live UWorld solving, and tailored podcasts. My teaching methods reduce the efforts of the students by almost 40 to 50%, and reinforce them with knowledge every single day.

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